

Well-deserved: Sainz (in pic) and Charles Leclerc made it a 1-2 for Ferrari. AP

At a time when there are rumours about whether Verstappen will stay at Red Bull next year, the team got a reality check on what its star driver brings to the table, even in a car that is by far the fastest by more than three-tenths.

Has Hamilton made the right choice?

Even as Ferrari celebrated a 1-2, Mercedes had a horror of a race in which both drivers failed to score points. Lewis Hamilton got knocked out in the second round of qualifying and had to start 11th. His race was eventually cut short by an engine failure.

In the other car, George Russell was doing slightly better, running seventh before he crashed out on the last lap of the race as he battled Fernando Alonso's Aston Martin. With Mercedes in no shape or form in the first three rounds, has Hamilton timed his exit from the team that fetched him six world titles from 2014 to 2020 to perfection?

Alonso's clever move

Two-time world champion Alonso, even at 42, is one of the fastest drivers on the current grid, capable of going toe-to-toe with anyone. While he is not the absolute fastest in qualifying, his relentless ability to be quick over a race distance and his tremendous racecraft allow him to maximise results on a Sunday.

In Melbourne, while trying to keep Russell at bay on the last lap, the Spaniard slowed early into the corner to get a better exit. However, Alonso's actions went a bit too far this time as he slowed drastically before increasing his speed and then slowed again before the corner.

Russell lost a lot of downforce as he got too close to Alonso and spun out into the barriers. The stewards felt that irrespective of Russell's crash, Alonso made an unusual manoeuvre and handed him a 20-second penalty that demoted him to eighth.



AP



REUTERS

Moto GP



Portuguese Grand Prix

Meanwhile, on two wheels, the reigning champion Francesco Bagnaia had a weekend to forget in the second round at the Portuguese Grand Prix in Portimao. On Saturday, the Italian squandered a race-winning position in the Sprint Race as he ran wide and slipped to fourth. It got worse on Sunday during the main race, when he and Marc Marquez came together and crashed out of the race even as his title-rival Jorge Martin (left) won comfortably ahead of pole-sitter Enea Bastianini. The win ensured Martin took an 18-point lead over KTM rider Brad Binder, with Bagnaia five points further behind in fourth. The race also saw reigning Moto2 champion Pedro Acosta get his maiden podium, finishing third in only his second race in the premier class.